



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MIN 730 (M) Carriage of cargoes: amendments to mandatory international instruments 2026

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Summary

The purpose of this Marine Information Note (MIN) is to advise of amendments to provisions in certain mandatory international instruments related to the carriage of cargoes by sea. These amendments will take effect in 2026 and relate to the following instruments:

- the International Code for the Safe Carriage of Grain in Bulk (International Grain Code)
- the International Code for the Construction and Equipment of Ships Carrying Liquefied Gases in Bulk (the IGC Code)
- the reporting requirements set out in Protocol I to the International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships (MARPOL)
- the International Maritime Solid Bulk Cargoes (IMSBC) Code

1. Introduction

1.1 Amendments to certain mandatory international instruments related to the carriage of cargoes have been agreed in the International Maritime Organization (IMO). These amendments enter into force in 2026 (or, in the case of the IMSBC Code, can be used on a voluntary basis). The amendments make a number of changes to the requirements for the carriage by sea of grain, solid bulk cargoes and liquified gases in bulk, and to the reporting requirements for incidents involving harmful substances. By virtue of the ambulatory reference provisions in the relevant UK regulations, these amendments will enter into force in the UK on the date on which they take effect internationally (see 1.2 and 1.3 below for further detail on ambulatory references). The relevant mandatory instruments, the key areas of change, and the relevant application dates are set out below.

Ambulatory Reference Provisions

1.2 Ambulatory Reference (AR) provisions are a tool used in some UK secondary legislation which enables the automatic implementation of amendments to international instruments into UK legislation. Where the UK legislation refers to an international instrument, such as a provision in a convention or a code forming part of that convention (for example, the IMSBC Code), this reference is 'ambulatory', that is, a reference to the most up to date version of that provision or code.

1.3 AR provisions help to ensure that UK legislation does not fall behind international standards. The amendments set out below will become mandatory in the UK by means of the ambulatory reference provision in the relevant UK implementing regulations.

2. Summary of amendments to the International Grain Code

2.1 The International Grain Code, adopted by resolution MSC.23(59) ([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.23\(59\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.23(59).pdf)), has been mandatory under SOLAS chapter VI since 1 January 1994. It applies to ships regardless of size, including those of less than 500 gross tonnage, engaged in the carriage of grain in bulk and to which part C of SOLAS chapter VI applies. The purpose of the Code is to provide an international standard for the safe carriage of grain in bulk. The International Grain Code is implemented in the UK by the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Cargoes) Regulations 2024 (<https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2024/637/made>).

2.2 The IMO's Maritime Safety Committee (MSC) agreed amendments to the code which set out a new class of loading conditions for ships with special compartments. These amendments were adopted in the IMO by resolution MSC.552(108) ([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.552\(108\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.552(108).pdf)) and amend both Part A Specific Requirements and Part B Calculation of assumed heeling moments and general assumptions.

2.3 In particular, the amendments introduce a definition for the term specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed, and make provisions for the stowage of bulk grain in such compartments.

2.4 These amendments to the International Grain Code enter into force internationally on **1 January 2026** and, by virtue of the ambulatory reference provisions in the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Cargoes) Regulations 2024, enter into force in the UK on the same date.

Relevant reference	Amendment
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Part A, 2 Definitions	Added after paragraph 2.7:
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2.8 The term specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed refers to a specially suitable compartment which is not filled to the maximum extent possible in way of the hatch opening but is filled to a level equal with or above the bottom edge of the hatch end beams and has not been trimmed outside the periphery of the hatch opening by the provisions of A 10.4.

Part A, 10 Stowage of bulk grain	The reference to “B 6” in paragraph 10.3.1 is replaced with “B 7”
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Part A, 10 Stowage of bulk grain	The following is inserted after existing paragraph 10.3 and the subsequent paragraphs are renumbered accordingly:
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10.4 In any “specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed”, the bulk grain shall be filled to a level equal with or above the bottom edge of the hatch end beams but may be at its natural angle of repose outside the periphery of the hatch opening. A compartment may qualify for this classification if it is “specially suitable” as defined in A 2.7, in which case dispensation may be granted from trimming the ends of that compartment.”

Part A, 10 Stowage of bulk grain	Renumbered paragraph 10.7 (existing paragraph 10.6) is replaced by:
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10.7 After loading, all free grain surfaces in partly filled compartments shall be level unless the compartment is partly filled in accordance with the provisions of A 10.4, in which case the free grain surface in way of the hatch opening only shall be level.

Relevant reference	Amendment
Part A, 10 Stowage of bulk grain	The reference to “B 5.2” in renumbered paragraph 10.10.3 (existing paragraph 10.9.3) is replaced with “B 6.2”.
Part A, 12 Divisions loaded on both sides	The reference to “A 12.1.3” in paragraph 12.3.3 is replaced with “A 12.1.2”.
Part A, 14 Saucers	The reference to “A 10.9” in paragraph 14.1 is replaced with “A 10.10”.
Part B, 1 General assumptions	A new paragraph 1.1.5 is added after existing paragraph 1.1.4: .5 In a “specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed” which is exempted from trimming under the provisions of A 10.4, it shall be assumed that the surface of the grain after loading will slope in all directions away from the filling area at an angle of 30° from the lower edge of the hatch end beam. However, if feeding holes are provided in the hatch end beams in accordance with table B 1-2 and the free grain surface in way of the hatch opening is above the level of the feeding holes, then the surface of the grain after loading shall be assumed to slope in all directions, at an angle of 30° from a line on the hatch end beam which is the mean of the peaks and valleys of the actual grain surface as shown in figure B-1.
Part B, 1 General assumptions	The reference to “B 5” in paragraph 1.2 is replaced with “B 6”.
Part B, 1 General assumptions	Paragraph 1.5 is replaced by the following: 1.5 In “partly filled compartments” and “specially suitable compartments, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed”, the adverse effect of the vertical shift of grain surfaces shall be taken into account as follows: Total heeling moment = 1.12 x calculated transverse heeling moment.

Relevant reference	Amendment
Part B, 2 Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a filled compartment, trimmed	The reference to “A 10.9” in paragraph 2.6 is replaced with “A 10.10”.
Part B, 2 Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a filled compartment, trimmed	The reference to “A 10.9” in the Note (2) for figure B 2-1 in paragraph 2.8 is replaced with “A 10.10”.
Part B, 2 Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a filled compartment, trimmed	The reference to “A 10.9” in the Note (3) for figure B 2-3 in paragraph 2.9 is replaced with “A 10.10”.
Part B, 3 Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a filled compartment, untrimmed	In paragraph 3.1, the word “provision” is replaced with “provisions”.
Part B, 4 Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed	A new section 4 is inserted after the existing section 3 (Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a filled compartment, untrimmed) and the subsequent sections and paragraphs are renumbered accordingly: 4 Assumed volumetric heeling moment of a specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed 4.1 All the provisions for “filled compartments, trimmed” set forth in B 2 shall also apply to “specially suitable compartments, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed” except as noted below. 4.2 In a “specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed” which is exempted from trimming under the provisions of A 10.4, the resulting grain surface

Relevant reference	Amendment
	in way of the hatch opening and the resulting grain surface in the ends, forward and aft of the hatchway, after shifting shall be assumed to be at an angle of 25° to the horizontal.
Part B, 5 Assumed volumetric heeling moments in trunks	The references to “figure B 4” in renumbered section 5 (Assumed volumetric heeling moments in trunks) are replaced with “figure B 5”.

3. Summary of amendments to the IGC Code

3.1 The IGC Code applies to gas carriers constructed on or after 1 July 1986. The purpose of the code is to provide an international standard for the safe transport in bulk by sea of liquefied gases, by prescribing the design and construction standards of ships involved in such transport and the equipment they should carry so as to minimise the risk to the ship, its crew and to the environment, having regard to the nature of the products involved. The IGC Code is implemented in the UK by the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Dangerous Goods and Harmful Substances) (Amendment) Regulations 2024 (<https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2024/636/made>).

3.2 Two sets of amendments to the IGC Code will enter into force in 2026. Firstly, amendments related to the addition of high manganese austenitic steel as a new material used in the construction of the cargo system on gas carriers and, secondly, amendments related to the use of cargoes as fuel for the ship.

High manganese austenitic steel

3.3 Amendments to the IGC Code adopted by resolution MSC.523(106) (<https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.523%28106%29.pdf>) replace table 6.3 in section 6.4 (Requirements for metallic materials) of the IGC Code. Table 6.3 is headed Plates, Sections and Forgings for Cargo Tanks, Secondary Barriers and Process Pressure Vessels for Design Temperatures Below -55°C and Down to -165°C Maximum Thickness 25 mm and it is replaced in its entirety. The new table 6.3 includes provisions for high manganese austenitic steel.

3.4 Resolution MSC.524(106)

(<https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.524%28106%29.pdf>), approved at the same time as MSC.523(106), makes the same change to Table 7.3 in the International Code of Safety for Ships Using Gases or Other Low-Flashpoint Fuels (the IGF Code).

3.5 This amendment to the IGC Code enters into force internationally on 1 January 2026 and, by way of the ambulatory reference provisions in the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Dangerous Goods and Harmful Substances) (Amendment) Regulations 2024, enters into force in the UK on the same date.

Use of cargo as fuel

3.6 Separately, amendments to the IGC Code regarding the use of cargo as fuel have been adopted by resolution MSC.566(109) ([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.566\(109\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.566(109).pdf)). In section 16.9 (Alternative fuels and technologies), paragraph 16.9.2 previously stated that the use of cargoes identified as toxic products was not permitted. This amendment refines paragraph 16.9.2 of the Code, meaning that the IGC Code is now more aligned with the fuels permitted for use under the IGF Code in the drive to decarbonise global shipping and reduce emissions.

3.7 The amended text of 16.9.2 is as follows:

16.9.2 The use of cargoes requiring carriage in type 1G ships, as identified in column “c” in the table of chapter 19, shall not be permitted. If acceptable to the Administration, cargoes identified as toxic products in column “f” which are required to be carried in type 2G/2PG ships in column “c” in the table of chapter 19 may be used as fuel, provided that the same level of safety as natural gas (methane) is ensured in accordance with the relevant provisions of this Code, including those in 1.3, and taking into account the guidelines developed by the Organization, after special consideration has been given by the Administration.

3.8 This amendment to the IGC Code will enter into force internationally on 1 July 2026 and, by way of the ambulatory reference provisions in the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Dangerous Goods and Harmful Substances) (Amendment) Regulations 2024, enters into force in the UK on the same date.

4. Summary of amendments to MARPOL Protocol 1

4.1 The International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships (MARPOL) sets out international requirements for the prevention of ship-source pollution. Protocol 1 of MARPOL establishes requirements for the reporting of incidents involving harmful substances.

4.2 Following the adoption of amendments to SOLAS Chapter V (safety of navigation), amendments to Protocol 1 of MARPOL have been agreed in the IMO in order to align the SOLAS chapter V reporting requirements with related requirements in Protocol 1. This amendment to Protocol 1 was adopted by Resolution MEPC.384(81)

([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MEPCDocuments/MEPC.384\(81\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MEPCDocuments/MEPC.384(81).pdf)).

4.3 Regulations 31 (danger messages) and 32 (information required in danger messages) of SOLAS chapter V have been amended by resolution MSC.550(108)

([https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.550\(108\).pdf](https://wwwcdn.imo.org/localresources/en/KnowledgeCentre/IndexofIMOResolutions/MSCResolutions/MSC.550(108).pdf)) in order to make mandatory the

reporting of lost freight containers. The amendment to regulation 32 sets out the information required in the danger message. This new SOLAS requirement applies to the loss of freight containers irrespective of their contents. Protocol 1 of MARPOL already requires the reporting of discharges or probable discharges of harmful substances including those in freight containers. This amendment to Protocol 1 requires that, where a report of the loss of freight container(s) is required by article II(1)(b) of Protocol 1, that report shall be made in accordance with the requirements for danger messages in SOLAS chapter V regulations 31 and 32. The full amendment to SOLAS Chapter V is set out in MIN 728 (M+F)

(<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/min728-mf-upcoming-solas-chapter-v-amendment-reporting-loss-of-containers-at-sea>).

4.4 Article V (Reporting procedures) of MARPOL Protocol 1 is amended with the following new paragraph 3 inserted after existing paragraph 2:

In case of the loss of freight container(s), the report required by article II(1)(b) shall be made in accordance with the requirements on danger messages as provided for in regulations V/31 and V/32 of the International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, 1974.

4.5 This amendment to MARPOL Protocol 1 will enter into force internationally on 1 January 2026. By virtue of the ambulatory reference provisions in the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Dangerous Goods and Harmful Substances) (Amendment) Regulations 2024, this amendment will enter into force in the UK on the same day.

5. Summary of amendments to the IMSBC Code

The International Maritime Solid Bulk Cargoes (IMSBC) Code

5.1 The IMSBC Code has been the mandatory international standard for the carriage of solid bulk cargoes by sea since 2011. The Code facilitates the safe loading, stowage, shipment and unloading of solid bulk cargoes. The Code provides information on the dangers associated with the shipment of certain types of solid bulk cargoes and instructions on the procedures to be adopted when the shipment of a solid bulk cargo is considered. The IMSBC Code is implemented in the UK by the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Cargoes) Regulations 2024 and the Merchant Shipping (Carriage of Dangerous Goods and Harmful Substances) (Amendment) Regulations 2024.

5.2 The IMSBC Code follows a two-year amendment cycle in the IMO meaning that a new edition of the Code is published by the IMO every two years. The latest edition of the Code, incorporating amendment 08-25, has been adopted in the IMO by resolution MSC.575(110). It will enter into force internationally on 1 January 2027 and can be applied on a voluntary basis from 1 January 2026.

5.3 Amendment 08-25 to the IMSBC Code makes several changes to the Code. A number of these are updates to references and editorial amendments and improvements. Other changes amend existing individual cargo schedules and introduce new ones. Amendments to the Code in amendment 08-25 include (see resolution MSC.575(110) for all amendments):

- In the individual schedule for “CASTOR BEANS or CASTOR MEAL or CASTOR POMACE or CASTOR FLAKE UN 2969”, the bulk cargo shipping name (BCSN) is replaced to read “CASTOR BEANS UN 2969” and in the table for “Characteristics”, in the box for “MHB”, the words “TX and/or CR” are inserted. In the section for “Hazard”, the sentence “This cargo is non-combustible or has a low fire risk.” is inserted at the end of the section. This amendment to the BCSN is intended to provide

clarification given that castor meal, castor pomace and castor flakes shall not be carried in bulk.

- A number of amendments are made to the individual schedules for DIRECT REDUCED IRON (A), Briquettes, Hot-Moulded and DIRECT REDUCED IRON (B), Lumps, Pellets, Cold-Moulded Briquettes, in particular, the addition of 'apparent density' in the cargo schedule to avoid poor quality briquettes which readily break into very small particles being shipped under these schedules as these can increase the self-heating hazard;
- Amendment to the Appendix section for the general requirements for carriage of Ferrosilicon with at least 25% but less than 30% silicon, or 90% or more silicon to include two sets of self-contained breathing apparatus to be carried in the ship in addition to those required by SOLAS regulation II-2/10.10. Self-contained breathing apparatus sets carried in accordance with SOLAS regulation II-2/19.3.6.2 may be used to comply with this requirement.
- The BCSN for FISH MEAL (FISH SCRAP), STABILISED Anti-oxidant treated is replaced to read "FISH MEAL (FISH SCRAP), STABILIZED UN 2216 Anti-oxidant treated. Moisture content greater than 5% but not exceeding 12%, by mass. Fat content not more than 15%". A number of other amendments are made to this cargo schedule, including in the Characteristics box, where the cargo is assigned to Class 9 and in the section for Precautions, where the levels of measurable anti-oxidant are amended for ethoxyquin.

5.4 The following new schedules have been added to Appendix I of the Code:

Bulk Cargo Shipping Name (BCSN)	Group
ALUMINIUM SULPHATE GRANULAR	B
APATITE CONCENTRATE	A
ASPHALT GRANULATES	C
CRUSHED GRANODIORITE, COARSE	C
FERRIC SULPHATE GRANULAR	B
FISH MEAL, STABILIZED	C
FISH SCRAP, STABILIZED	C
IRON ORE BRIQUETTES	C

Bulk Cargo Shipping Name (BCSN)	Group
PEA PROTEIN CONCENTRATE PELLETS	C
PHOSPHATE ROCK FINES (uncalcined)	A
TUFF, COARSE	C
ZINC SLAG (coarse)	C

5.5 Internationally, and in the UK:

From **1 January 2026 until 31 December 2026**, solid bulk cargoes must be shipped either:

- a) In accordance with the mandatory IMSBC Code 2023 Edition incorporating amendment 07-23; or
- b) In accordance with the IMSBC Code 2025 Edition incorporating amendment 08-25.

5.6 On or after 1 January 2027, solid bulk cargoes other than grain must be shipped only in accordance with the IMSBC Code 2025 Edition incorporating amendment 08-25.

5.7 The IMSBC Code is available from the IMO, 1 Albert Embankment, London SE1 7SR. The Annex to IMO Resolution MSC.575(110) contains the amendments to the Code.

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